490.LIFE · DEEPER STUDY · STUDY GUIDE

Worship in Spirit and Truth

John 4:23–24 · Revelation 1:4–6 · Leviticus 10:1–3



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New to this? This is one of our Deeper Studies, a long and careful study. If you are just starting out, begin with the five-page short version, Worship in Spirit and Truth, then come back here when you are ready to dig in.

Introduction: A Tale of Two Funerals

If you want to know what a church believes about God, go to one of its funerals. A Sunday morning can hide a lot. A graveside hides almost nothing.

Gene Edward Veith once wrote about two funerals he attended. Both were for young people. Both deaths were senseless. The first was for a teenage boy killed in an accident. His friends wore T-shirts printed with his picture. Footballs, flowers, and stuffed animals were heaped at the front of the church, and his prom photo sat on the coffin. The service opened with a recording of his favorite heavy metal ballad. The preacher told funny stories about him and the dreams he had for his life. His best friend tried to speak and broke down. His girlfriend read a poem. His father stood up and somehow got through a few words. Then the lights went down for a video of his life: baby pictures, Christmas mornings, a boy waving at the camera. There was not a dry eye in the room, and on the way out people said, "What a beautiful funeral."

The second funeral was for a girl who had been raped and murdered by a serial killer. Veith was one of the elders on duty, and his job that day was to keep the news cameras away from the family. The congregation sang old hymns in a minor key, hymns about the death and resurrection of Jesus. They read Scripture back and forth together. The pastor did not give a eulogy. He told them the plain facts of her life: her baptism, her catechism classes, her confession of faith, the Lord's Supper she had received at that very table. Then he opened the Bible and preached about our sorrows in this broken world, about the Son of God who entered our condition, and about the sure hope that this child was now with him. They wept. Of course they wept. But Veith said the first service "deals with grief by indulging it, even feeding it," while at the second "the Word of God that permeated the whole service was like a lifeline."



The same grief, two very different services. What we do when we gather shows what we believe about God.

The difference had nothing to do with music style, or old people versus young people, or organs versus guitars. Voddie Baucham, who reads this story in a sermon on worship, makes the point well: “This was not a matter of preference. This was a matter of fundamental presuppositions.” The first service was built around the young man and around what the people in the room needed to feel. The second was built around who God is, and around what God has said about death, about sin, and about the hope we have in Christ. One tried to manage the room. The other told the truth about God and trusted that it would be enough.

It was enough. It always is.

I serve on a worship team at my church, so I think about this every week, and I suspect you do too, whether you lead or simply stand in the row and sing. What makes worship good? When you walk out of church and say, “That was great this morning,” what do you mean? This study is an attempt to answer that from the Bible. We will ask what worship is, who decides what pleases God, why we worship Jesus, how sinners can worship at all, and what to do with our hearts and our feelings when we do. Along the way we will lean on faithful teachers: John Calvin, the Puritans, Jonathan Edwards, and in our own day R. C. Sproul, John MacArthur, John Piper, and Tim Keller.

One note before we begin. This is not a study about style. Churches that love the Bible sing old hymns and new songs, with organs and with guitars, and the Bible gives us real freedom there. What it does not give us is freedom about the substance. Baucham ended his sermon with a line worth keeping: “It’s not about style. It’s about substance.”

The Word: Bowing Down

> **Matthew 4:10** *"Be gone, Satan! For it is written, 'You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve.'"*

In the wilderness the devil showed Jesus all the kingdoms of the world and offered him every one of them for a single act. "All these I will give you, if you will fall down and worship me" (Matt. 4:9). Jesus answered with Deuteronomy. The word he used for worship is the most common worship word in the New Testament:

προσκυνέω *(proskyneō)*

"to worship, to bow down before." To show by posture that someone is greater than you

πρός (pros)

"toward"

A common prefix. The compound's meaning comes from how it is used, not from its parts.

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κυνέω (kyneō)

"to kiss"

In the ancient world, people bowed low and kissed the ground or the feet of a king.

Payoff: The parts paint a picture, but usage gives the meaning. The standard Greek lexicon (BDAG) defines the word as expressing "complete dependence on or submission to a high authority figure." It is the word the Greek Old Testament uses for bowing to the ground, as in Psalm 95:6, "Oh come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD, our Maker!" Words from this family appear ten times in Jesus' conversation with the Samaritan woman (John 4:20–24) and more than twenty times in Revelation. In that book everyone bows to someone. Heaven bows to God and the Lamb (Rev. 5:14). The world bows to the beast (Rev. 13:4, 8). And when John falls at the feet of an angel, the angel stops him: "Worship God" (Rev. 19:10). Worship begins with bowing. Before it is music, it is submission.

Jesus also put a second word beside the first: "him only shall you *serve*." That word, *latreuō*, is the language of religious service, used of all Israel serving God (Exod. 3:12), not only of priests. We will come back to it. For now, notice that in Jesus' mind the two go together. You serve whatever you bow to. Worship is never only a feeling in the chest. It is the whole person bent toward someone, in posture, in loyalty, and in life.

Here is a working definition to carry through the rest of the study. **True worship is the response of redeemed people to who God is and what he has done: offered to the Father, through the Son, by the Spirit, in the way he has given us, with the whole of our lives.** Each piece of that sentence is a part of this study.

Part One: Everyone Worships

We tend to think of worship as a religious activity, something believers do on Sundays and other people skip. The Bible sees it the other way around. Every human being is a worshiper. The only question is what we worship.

> **Romans 1:21, 25** *"For although they knew God, they did not honor him as God or give thanks to him, but they became futile in their thinking, and their foolish hearts were darkened. … They exchanged the truth about God for a lie and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator, who is blessed forever! Amen."*

Paul does not say the human race stopped worshiping when it turned from God. He says it exchanged one object for another. The heart did not go quiet. It moved its loyalty somewhere else. And notice the same pair of words Jesus used: they "worshiped and served" the creature.

John Calvin, the Reformer of Geneva, saw this as clearly as anyone. "The human mind," he wrote, "is, so to speak, a perpetual forge of idols." A forge never cools. It is always heating something up and hammering it into shape. Calvin also saw how it happens: "The mind, in this way, conceives the idol, and the hand gives it birth." First we imagine a god we would like, and then we build our lives around him.

Tim Keller spent much of his ministry in Manhattan helping secular people see this about themselves. "We will either worship the uncreated God, or we will worship some created thing (an idol). There is no possibility of our worshiping nothing." Then he added a line that cuts close: "Whatever we worship we will serve." Look at a person's calendar and bank statement and you will usually see their god. A career, a child, a body, a reputation, a political cause, a romance. These are good gifts, most of them. They become idols when we ask them to give us what only God can give, which Keller described as "the sense of purity, value, and acceptability that only Jesus can give."

This matters for a study on worship because it tells us that worship is not a hobby for the religious. It is the deepest thing about being human. It also warns us that the forge does not shut down when we walk into church. A Christian can bring his idols to the sanctuary and bow to them there. We can worship the experience of worship. We can worship a style, a band, a preacher, or the feeling we had last Easter. The question is never only "Am I worshiping?" It is "Whom am I worshiping, and on whose terms?"

That second question takes us to the hardest chapter in this study.

Part Two: Who Sets the Terms?

> **Leviticus 10:1–3** *"Now Nadab and Abihu, the sons of Aaron, each took his censer and put fire in it and laid incense on it and offered unauthorized fire before the LORD, which he had not commanded them. And fire came out from before the LORD and consumed them, and they died before the LORD. Then Moses said to Aaron, 'This is what the LORD has said: "Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."' And Aaron held his peace."*

This is one of the most unsettling stories in the Bible, and it is meant to be. The tabernacle had just been dedicated. Aaron and his sons had been ordained as priests. Fire had come out from the LORD and consumed the first offering on the altar, and all the people shouted and fell on their faces (Lev. 9:24). It was the happiest day Israel had known since the Red Sea. Then two of Aaron's sons, priests themselves, men who had eaten with God on the mountain (Exod. 24:9–11), took their censers and offered incense in a way God had not asked for. The same fire that had accepted the offering came out again and killed them.

What was their sin? Moses describes it by what was missing. They offered fire "which he had not commanded them." The Hebrew words are worth slowing down for:

אֵשׁ זָרָה *(ʾēsh zārāh)*

"unauthorized fire" (ESV), "strange fire" (KJV). Fire that did not belong

אֵשׁ (ʾēsh)

"fire"

The ordinary word. The fire itself was not the problem.

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זָרָה (zārāh)

"strange, foreign, outside"

Used of a stranger, someone not of the household. Here, worship that came from somewhere other than God's word.

Payoff: The same word describes the incense Israel was forbidden to offer on the golden altar: "You shall not offer unauthorized incense on it" (Exod. 30:9). God had told his priests exactly how to come near, and anything else was strange to him. Incense was commanded. Fire was commanded. The sin was that they decided for themselves how to approach a holy God. God's answer is the center of the whole passage: "Among those who are near me I will be sanctified." Worship exists to treat God as holy. When we set the terms, we have quietly made ourselves the holy one.



"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified" (Lev. 10:3). God himself decides how he will be approached.

R. C. Sproul spent his life helping Christians feel the weight of God's holiness, and he went straight to this text. Nadab and Abihu died, he wrote, because God was "reminding Israel of the sanctity of His presence." His conclusion was simple: "We are to worship God how God wants us to worship Him." John MacArthur put it more sharply still: "The most serious crimes against God occur in corrupt worship."

The rest of Scripture keeps the same line. Moses told Israel, "Everything that I command you, you shall be careful to do. You shall not add to it or take from it" (Deut. 12:32). Through Jeremiah God condemned the child sacrifice Israel had invented, which his law had already forbidden (Lev. 18:21), in words that show how far it was from his heart: "which I did not command, nor did it come into my mind" (Jer. 7:31). And Jesus told the Samaritan woman, "You worship what you do not know" (John 4:22). Sincerity was not the issue. She was sincere. She simply did not know the God she was trying to approach.

Three Ways to Answer the Question

At the Reformation in the 1500s this question divided the Protestant churches. The Reformers agreed that the medieval church had filled its worship with things God never asked for. They disagreed about what to do next. Sam Waldron, a Reformed Baptist theologian, sums up the history: "The 'Conservative Reformation' of Luther adopted the policy of preserving the worship of Medieval Catholicism except where it contradicted Scripture." Calvin and the Reformed churches went further. They asked not only "What does the Bible forbid?" but "What has God actually told us to do?" Calvin knew how hard this would be to accept: "I know how difficult it is to persuade the world that God disapproves of all modes of worship not expressly sanctioned by His Word."

These two answers came to be called the **normative principle** (we may do whatever Scripture does not forbid) and the **regulative principle** (we offer God only what his Word commands, whether stated outright or drawn from it by necessary inference, WCF 1.6). Baucham's sermon adds a third, one that nobody would ever write into a confession but that runs a great many churches today. He calls it the **affective principle**: "If somebody likes it and it makes them feel close to God, it's good."



The affective principle is not new. Calvin was already arguing against it in 1543. He described people who believed that whatever they did in worship "has in itself a sufficient sanction, provided it exhibits some kind of zeal for the honour of God." In other words, if it feels earnest, God must be pleased. Calvin's answer was that we "may not adopt any device which seems fit to ourselves, but look to the injunctions of Him who alone is entitled to prescribe."

This matters for ordinary Christians who will never sit on a worship committee. The affective principle quietly turns worship around. It makes my experience the test of whether God was honored. It asks "Did I meet God?" before it asks "Did God receive what he asked for?" Baucham noticed that the old fight between "traditional" and "contemporary" worship was usually two versions of the same mistake: both sides argued about which style made them feel closer to God, and almost no one asked what God had said.

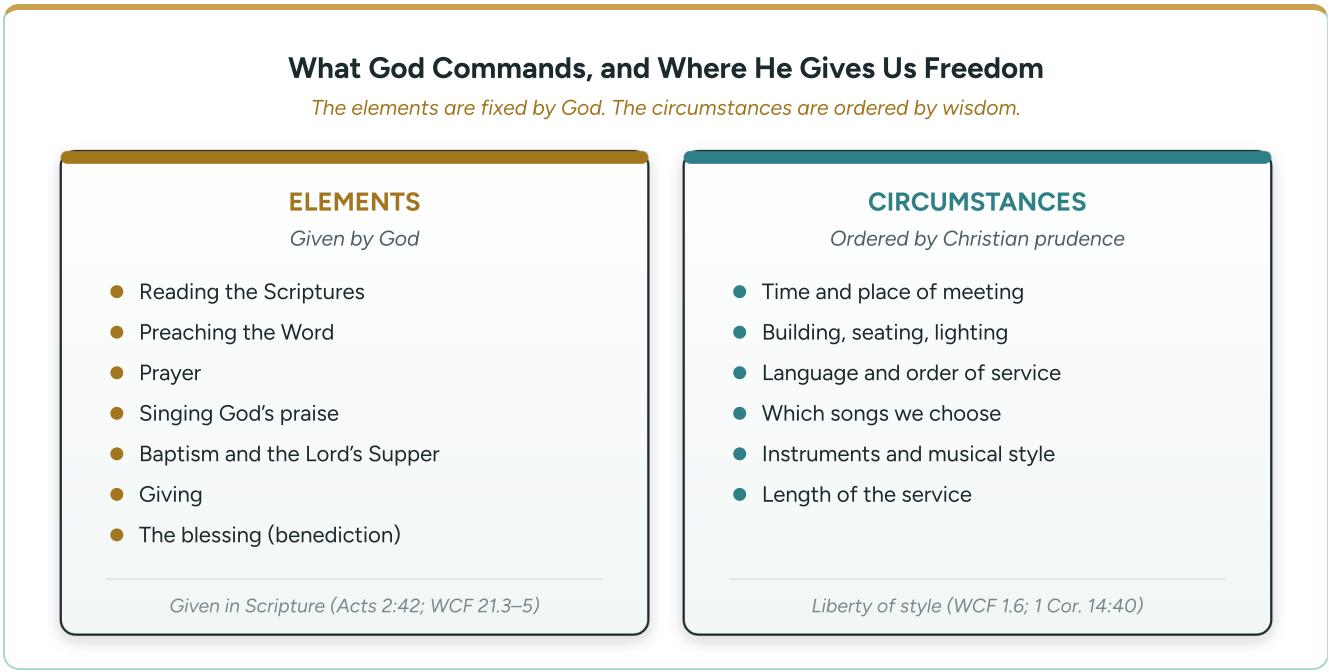
What God Commands, and Where He Gives Us Freedom

The Reformed confessions, the statements of faith written by Protestant churches in the 1500s and 1600s, give us a gift that keeps this from becoming rigid or joyless. The Westminster Confession (1646) states the principle plainly:

> **Westminster Confession 21.1** *"The acceptable way of worshiping the true God is instituted by himself, and so limited by his own revealed will, that he may not be worshiped according to the imaginations and devices of men… or any other way not prescribed in the Holy Scripture."*

The Heidelberg Catechism (1563), a teaching guide of questions and answers, says the same thing more gently. The second commandment teaches "that we in no way make any image of God nor worship him in any other way than has been commanded in God's Word" (Q&A 96). And it adds a wonderful line: "we should not try to be wiser than God" (Q&A 98).

But the same Westminster divines also said that some things about worship are "common to human actions and societies," and that these are "to be ordered by the light of nature, and Christian prudence, according to the general rules of the Word" (WCF 1.6). They called these the **circumstances** of worship, as distinct from its **elements**. This distinction is the key to the whole subject.



The *elements* are the parts of worship God himself has given: the reading and preaching of his Word, prayer, singing his praise, and the sacraments of baptism and the Lord's Supper (WCF 21.3–5; Acts 2:42; Col. 3:16; 1 Tim. 4:13). To these the New Testament adds the offering for the saints (1 Cor. 16:1–2) and the blessing spoken over God's people (2 Cor. 13:14). These are not up for a vote. A church that drops the preaching of the Word for a skit, or the Lord's Supper for a video, has changed the substance.

The *circumstances* are everything a gathering of people needs to happen at all: what time we meet, what building we use, what language we speak, whether we sit in pews or chairs, and how long the service runs. Most Reformed churches today treat the choice of songs, the instruments that carry the tune, and the musical style the same way. The Bible does not legislate these details, and we should not pretend it does. Here the church is free, guided by wisdom, love, and the general rules of Scripture: everything done "decently and in order" (1 Cor. 14:40), for building up (1 Cor. 14:26), so that outsiders can understand (1 Cor. 14:23–25), and with love for the weaker brother (Rom. 15:1–3).

So the regulative principle, rightly understood, does not hand us a rulebook for musical taste. Piper has rightly pointed out that in the New Testament "there is a stunning indifference to the outward forms and places of worship." What the principle protects is the center. God decides what we bring him. We decide, with prayer and humility, how to arrange the room. Keller, borrowing from John Frame, had a good word for those who drift into calling everything sin: "It is a bad habit of mind to seek to label as forbidden what is really just unwise." He also warned the other direction. Our preferences, he wrote, "should never be the driving force."

The Reformed principle and the liberty of style belong together. A hymn with a pipe organ and a modern song with an acoustic guitar can both be faithful worship if they carry the truth of God to the people of God. And either one can be empty if it becomes the thing we came for.

Part Three: In Spirit and Truth

> **John 4:23–24** *"But the hour is coming, and is now here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father is seeking such people to worship him. God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."*

It is noon at a well in Samaria. A tired Jewish rabbi asks a woman for a drink, and within a few minutes he has told her everything she has ever done. She does what most of us do when a conversation gets too close. She changes the subject to a religious debate. "Our fathers worshiped on this mountain, but you say that in Jerusalem is the place where people ought to worship" (John 4:20). Which mountain? Which building? Which style?

Jesus does not take the bait, and he does not dismiss the question either. He answers a deeper one. The hour has come when the *where* of worship will no longer matter, because the *who* and the *how* have arrived. The true temple is standing in front of her (John 2:19–21).



"The Father is seeking such people to worship him" (John 4:23). The seeker at the well was God.

ἐν πνεύματι καὶ ἀληθείᾳ *(en pneumati kai alētheia)*

"in spirit and truth." One phrase, not two separate requirements

πνεῦμα (pneuma)

"spirit"

In John, the life the Holy Spirit gives (John 3:5–8; 7:39). Worship born from above, no longer tied to a mountain.

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ἀλήθεια (alētheia)

"truth"

In John, the reality God has revealed in Jesus: "grace and truth came through Jesus Christ" (1:17); "I am the way, and the truth, and the life" (14:6).

Payoff: In Greek a single preposition governs both nouns, so Jesus is describing one kind of worship from two sides. It is easy to hear "spirit" as "sincere feelings" and "truth" as "correct doctrine," and then argue about which one matters more. But Jesus grounds it in God himself: "God is spirit." God is not bound to a mountain or a building, and true worship fits who he is. It comes to the Father, made possible by the Spirit, through the Son who is the Truth. That is a Trinitarian sentence hiding in a conversation at a well.

John Piper applies the phrase to our hearts and minds. "Worshiping in spirit is the opposite of worshiping in mere external ways. It's the opposite of formalism and traditionalism. Worshiping in truth is the opposite of worship based on an inadequate view of God." And then the line every worship leader should tape to his music stand: "Truth without emotion produces dead orthodoxy and a church full of unspiritual fighters. Emotion without truth produces empty frenzy and cultivates flaky people who reject the discipline of rigorous thought."

The Only Seeker There Is

Do not miss the most surprising phrase in the passage: "the Father is seeking such people to worship him." We usually think of worship as us looking for God. Jesus says it is God looking for worshipers. And the proof is sitting in front of him. A tired Jewish rabbi, resting at a Samaritan well at noon, has started a conversation with a woman with a broken past. Before the day is over she is running into town telling everyone about him (John 4:28–29).

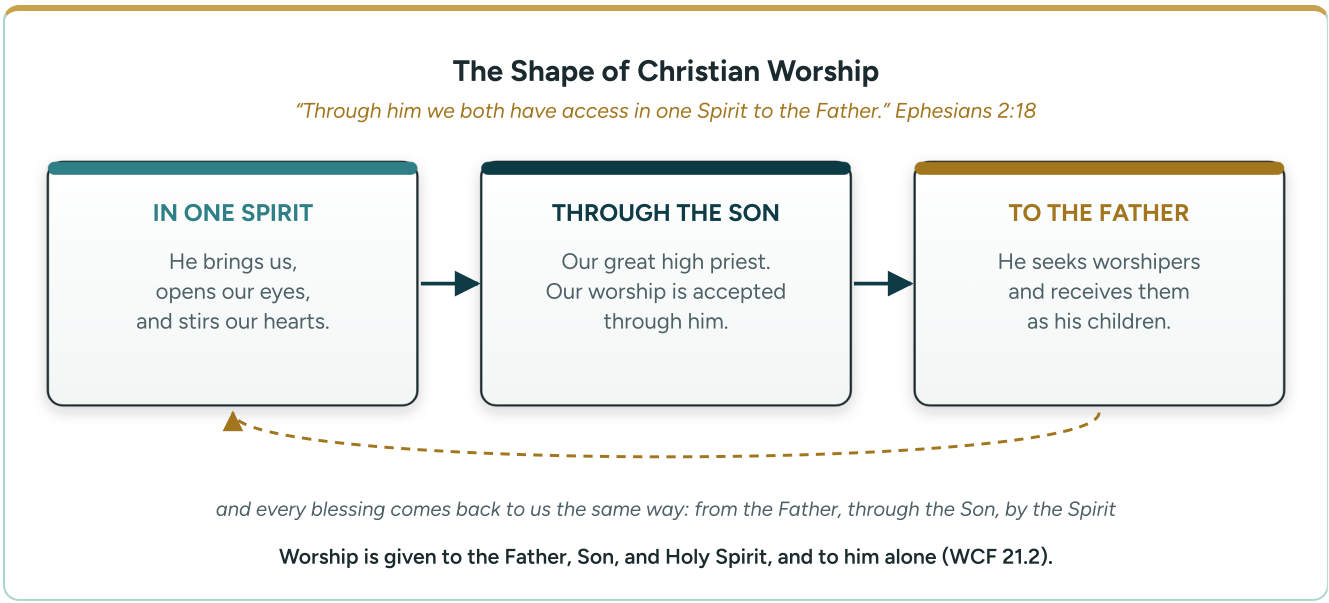
Paul says plainly that left to ourselves "no one seeks for God" (Rom. 3:11). Our seeking is always an answer to his. Baucham said it with a smile: if he were ever going to run a "seeker service," the kind many churches design around visitors, it would be a John 4 seeker service, where God is the one doing the seeking. Piper says it simply: "The work of God is to seek real worshipers. Jesus was sent to accomplish this work."

This changes how we walk into church. We do not come to talk God into showing up. We come because he has already come looking for us.

Worship Is Trinitarian

"In spirit and truth" leads us to something Baucham presses hard: worship should be clearly and gladly Trinitarian. He made an uncomfortable observation. A visitor could attend many of our churches for a month, listen to the songs, the prayers, and the sermons, and never learn that we believe in the Trinity. We love Jesus, and that is right. But do we ever speak of the Father who sent him, or the Spirit who brings us to him? Baucham called it being "functional unitarians."

The New Testament pattern is clear: "through him we both have access in one Spirit to the Father" (Eph. 2:18). We come *to* the Father, *through* the Son, *by* the Spirit. The Westminster Confession adds that worship is due to all three: "Religious worship is to be given to God, the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost; and to him alone" (WCF 21.2).



John Owen, the greatest of the Puritan theologians, wrote a whole book on this, *Of Communion with God*. His central claim was that believers enjoy real fellowship with each person of the Trinity: "the saints have distinct communion with the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit (that is, distinctly with the Father, and distinctly with the Son, and distinctly with the Holy Spirit)." The Father loves us. The Son brings us grace. The Spirit comforts and seals us. Worship that knows this has three reasons to sing instead of one.

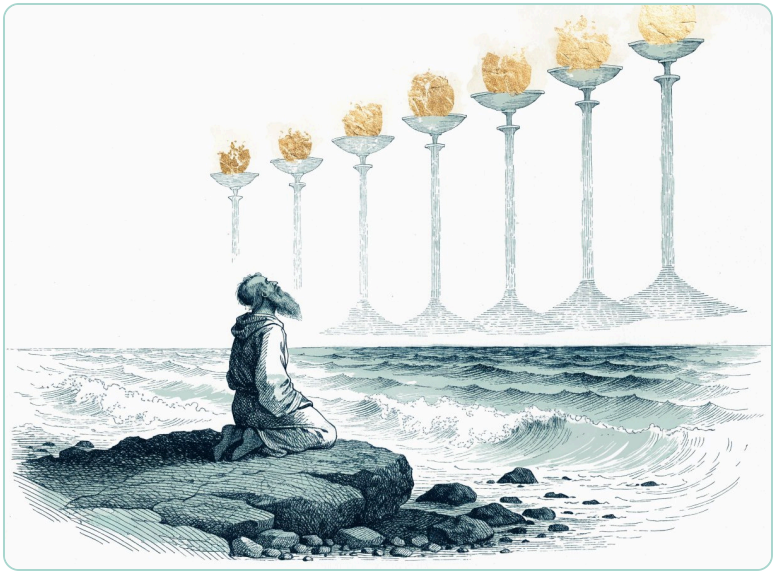
Why does this matter? Baucham gave a reason that goes to the heart of the gospel. The Trinity is what makes Jesus worthy of worship. If Jesus is only a great moral example, we may admire him, but we may not worship him. Great examples are not worthy of worship. But the Son is God, "very God of very God," as the Nicene Creed says, who took on flesh to save us. And the Trinity is what makes "God is love" (1 John 4:8) more than a slogan. Before the world was made, the Father loved the Son, and the Son loved the Father, in the fellowship of the Spirit (John 14:31; 17:24). Love is not something God picked up when he created us. It is who he has always been. Our redemption comes out of that love: the Father gives a people to the Son, the Son lays down his life for them, and the Spirit brings them home.

Part Four: Worthy: Why We Worship Jesus

> **Revelation 1:4–6** *"John to the seven churches that are in Asia: Grace to you and peace from him who is and who was and who is to come, and from the seven spirits who are before his throne, and from Jesus Christ the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, and the ruler of kings on earth. To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood and made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father, to him be glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen."*

John is an old man on a prison island called Patmos when he writes these words. The churches he loves are small, poor, and under pressure from Rome to bow to Caesar. He begins his letter to them with a greeting that quietly reorganizes the universe.

Look at where the grace comes from. It comes "from him who is and who was and who is to come," an echo of the name God gave Moses at the burning bush (Exod. 3:14). It comes "from the seven spirits who are before his throne." Seven in Revelation is the number of fullness, and most commentators take this as the Holy Spirit in his completeness, pictured as the seven lamps burning before God's throne (Rev. 4:5; Zech. 4:2–6). And it comes "from Jesus Christ." Father, Spirit, Son. John opens the last book of the Bible the way the church has always prayed: in the name of the Triune God.



On Patmos, John sees the risen Christ among seven golden lampstands, which are the seven churches (Rev. 1:12, 20).

Then John slows down to say three things about Jesus. Baucham noticed that John even breaks the order we might expect, Father, Son, and Spirit, so that he can put the Son last and linger over him. This is, after all, "the revelation of Jesus Christ" (Rev. 1:1).

He is "the faithful witness." Everything Jesus said about the Father is true. He is the one witness who never shades the truth. In a world of spin and lies, there is one voice you can trust completely.

He is "the firstborn of the dead." Others had been raised before him. Lazarus walked out of his tomb. But Baucham points out the obvious thing we forget: Lazarus died again. When Jesus rose, he rose never to die again (Rom. 6:9). He is the firstborn, the first of a whole family who will follow him out of the grave.

He is "the ruler of kings on earth." Caesar thought he was. He was not. The little churches of Asia, under pressure to honor the emperor as a god, needed to hear who actually sits on the throne.

That is why we worship Jesus. Before we say anything about what he has done for us, we say who he is. He is God the Son, the faithful witness, the risen Lord, the King of kings. Even if he had done nothing for us at all, he would be worthy of all our praise.

"To Him Who Loves Us"

But he has done something for us. Now John bursts into praise: "To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood." In Greek, "loves" is in the present tense and "freed" is in the past. His love goes on today, and it rests on something finished. The cross is done. The love is ongoing.

Baucham makes a pastoral point here that I have not been able to forget. We love to sing that Jesus loves us, and we should. But if we get there too fast, we shrink it. The size of a love depends on who is doing the loving. His dog adores him, he says, but that dog was bred to. His children's love means more, and the love of a wife who chose him means more still. Now go up from there. The one who loves you is the second person of the Trinity, the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, the ruler of the kings of the earth.

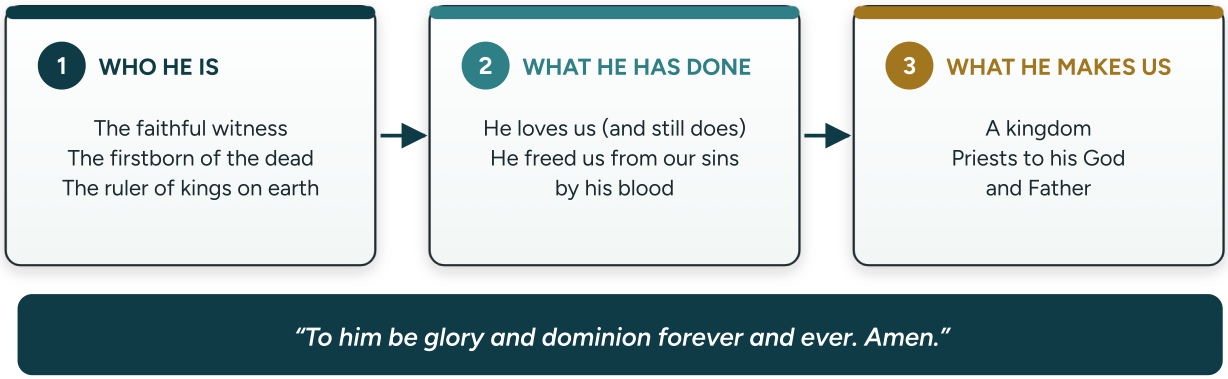
That is the problem with much of our worship, Baucham says. In man-centered worship, we end up celebrating "the fact that Jesus was smart enough to figure out how lovable we are." That is backwards. Start with who he is, and only then can you begin to feel the weight of the words "he loves me."

And notice how John says that love was shown: "freed us from our sins by his blood." This is love that paid. The word "freed" carries the sound of the exodus, when God redeemed a nation of slaves out of Egypt. We were slaves to sin, and he bought us out with his own blood (1 Pet. 1:18–19). Worship that never mentions sin, never mentions the cross, and never mentions blood has cut the love of Jesus loose from the thing that proves it.

A note on the King James reading. Some older Bibles read "washed us from our sins in his own blood." In Greek the difference between "freed" (*lusanti*) and "washed" (*lousanti*) is one letter. The oldest manuscripts read "freed," which is why modern translations have it. Both are true of what Christ did, and either way, the blood is the price.

Why We Worship Jesus: Revelation 1:5–6

Start with who he is. Only then can we feel the weight of his love.



He is worthy of worship, and he makes our worship acceptable (1 Pet. 2:5).

Part Five: Made Worthy: A Kingdom of Priests

John has one more thing to say, and it may be the most important for understanding worship. Jesus "made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father" (Rev. 1:6).

To feel the force of that, go back to Mount Sinai. God brought Israel out of Egypt and said, "You shall be to me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation" (Exod. 19:6). A priest is someone allowed to come near. In Israel, only the priests could enter the holy place, and only the high priest could go behind the curtain into the Most Holy Place, once a year, never without blood (Heb. 9:7). Remember Nadab and Abihu. Coming near to God was not casual. It was dangerous.

βασίλειον ἱεράτευμα *(basileion hierateuma)*

"a royal priesthood" (1 Pet. 2:9), from the Greek Old Testament of Exodus 19:6

βασίλειον (basileion)

"royal, belonging to a king"

A people who belong to the King and share in his rule.

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ἱεράτευμα (hierateuma)

"a body of priests"

Not one priest standing between God and the people, but a whole people who may draw near.

Payoff: Peter takes the calling God gave Israel at Sinai and says it now belongs to everyone who trusts in Christ (1 Pet. 2:9). John says the same thing twice in Revelation (1:6; 5:10). What Israel was called to be, the church is, and it is all because of the blood of the Lamb. That is why the line in Revelation 1 runs in this order: he loves us, he freed us by his blood, and he made us priests. The priesthood is the result of the rescue.

> **1 Peter 2:5** *"You yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ."*

Read that slowly and notice the last three words. Our worship is "acceptable to God *through Jesus Christ*." It is never acceptable because we sang well, or the band was tight, or we felt close to God. It is acceptable because Jesus, our great high priest, has opened the way.

> **Hebrews 10:19–22** *"Therefore, brothers, since we have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus, by the new and living way that he opened for us through the curtain, that is, through his flesh, and since we have a great priest over the house of God, let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith."*



"The new and living way that he opened for us through the curtain, that is, through his flesh" (Heb. 10:20).

Baucham makes a turn here, and I think he is exactly right. Jesus is worthy of worship because of who he is and what he has done. But Jesus also makes us able to worship. Baucham's phrase is that "Christ makes us worthy to worship," and he means acceptable, not deserving. "Apart from us being this kingdom of priests," he said, "there is nothing that we can offer to God that is acceptable." Our songs, our prayers, our gifts, and our lives are all stained. They reach the Father only because they pass through the hands of the Son.

That should humble us, and it should free us. It humbles us because it means no one can earn a place in worship by talent or effort. It frees us because the struggling believer who can barely get a song out on a hard Sunday is offering worship just as acceptable as the most gifted singer in the room, if both come through Christ.

What About Those Who Do Not Yet Believe?

This raises a fair question. If only the redeemed can offer worship that pleases God, how should a church think about the unbelievers who walk through its doors on Sunday?

For a generation, many churches answered by building their services around the visitor. Find out what unchurched people want, and give it to them. Baucham, MacArthur, and Sproul all pushed back hard on this. MacArthur warned that the seeker model "turns the church into a marketing agency that says what it thinks its supposed customers want to hear." Sproul wrote that worship "must not be designed to please the unbeliever or the believer." It is designed to please God. Baucham's point is the deepest one: you cannot design a worship service for people who are not yet able to worship.

But Scripture does expect unbelievers to be present when the church gathers, and Paul cares what happens to them:

> **1 Corinthians 14:24–25** *"But if all prophesy, and an unbeliever or outsider enters, he is convicted by all, he is called to account by all, the secrets of his heart are disclosed, and so, falling on his face, he will worship God and declare that God is really among you."*

Tim Keller took this text seriously. He wrote that "Paul directly tells a local congregation to adapt its worship because of the presence of unbelievers." Yet he still rejected the idea that worship should be aimed at them. He wrote that advocates of the seeker service had admitted that "the straight 'seeker service' is not really worship." His answer was to aim the service at God and let outsiders overhear it: "If they aim primarily at evangelism, they will bore the saints. If they aim primarily at education, they'll bore and confuse unbelievers. If they aim at praising the God who saves by grace, they'll both instruct insiders and challenge outsiders."

So the biblical balance runs like this. Worship is offered by God's people to God. It is never a show put on for an audience. But it is offered in a language outsiders can understand, by people who expect God to be present, so that a visitor watching a family of forgiven sinners praise their Savior might find the secrets of his heart laid bare, and fall on his face, and worship. Something like that happened at the well in Samaria. A woman who did not know what she worshiped met the Seeker, and many in her town came to believe (John 4:39). Every person owes God praise (Ps. 117:1), so unbelieving friends and family are always welcome to come and hear.

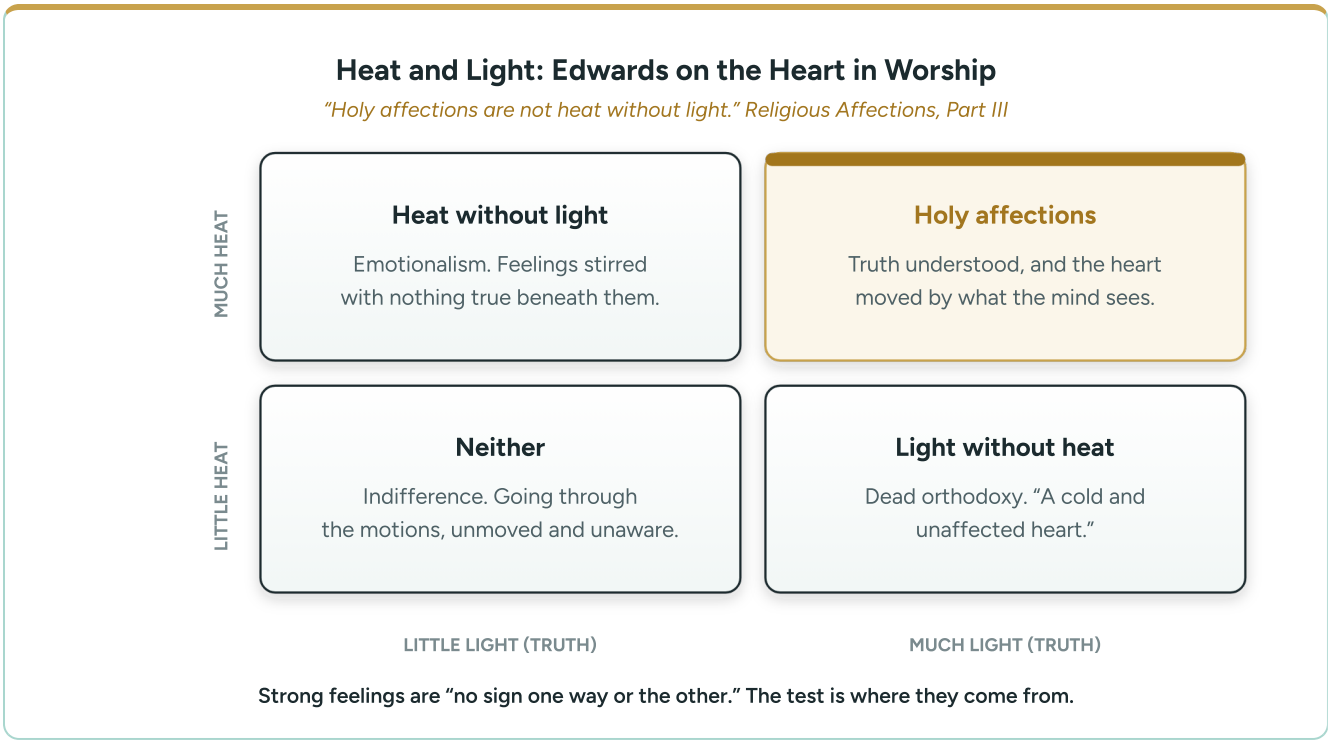
Part Six: Heart and Head

So far we have said a lot about truth. Someone might be worried by now. Is the answer to emotional worship just to stop feeling things? Should a faithful church be quiet, careful, and cold?

No. Jonathan Edwards lived through the Great Awakening, a season when emotions ran very high, some of them from God and some of them not. He wrote *Religious Affections* to help people tell the difference, and his opening claim surprises people who expect an old New England pastor to frown on

feelings: “True religion, in great part, consists in holy affections.” A faith that never moves the heart is not true faith.

But then Edwards adds the guardrail: “Holy affections are not heat without light; but evermore arise from the information of the understanding, some spiritual instruction that the mind receives.” True feeling comes from seeing something true about God. You are moved because you have understood something. The light comes first, and the heat follows.



Edwards saw the danger on both sides. “Where there is heat without light, there can be nothing divine or heavenly in that heart.” That is the affective principle: feelings stirred up by music, lights, or atmosphere, with nothing true underneath. But he also warned against “a kind of light without heat, a head stored with notions and speculations, with a cold and unaffected heart.” That is dead orthodoxy, the church that has every doctrine right and has never once been moved by any of them.

Then he made an observation that should comfort and humble all of us: “It is no sign one way or the other, that religious affections are very great, or raised very high.” Strong emotion in worship does not prove that God was there. And a quiet Sunday when you felt very little does not prove he was absent. The test is not how high the feelings went. The test is where they came from and where they led.

John MacArthur says the same thing in his own blunt way: “True worship is a response of adoration and praise prompted by truth that God has revealed.” The way to more of it is not more volume: “If you want to worship the Lord in a greater way, it doesn’t mean turn up the band.” It means knowing God better.

Gravity and Gladness

John Piper has spent his life on this balance. His most famous sentence is really a sentence about worship: "God is most glorified in us when we are most satisfied in him." It is a modern echo of the Westminster Shorter Catechism's first answer: "Man's chief end is to glorify God, and to enjoy him forever." Worship is not a duty we perform while our hearts are elsewhere. At its core it is delight in God.

But Piper is just as concerned about shallow delight. He calls for gravity and gladness together. "Without a healthy dose of gravity, worship will be trifling, it will be trivial, it will be thin, it will be superficial, it will degenerate to entertainment." He even says, "Chipper is the worst word I can think of to describe worship." God is holy. The cross was real. Eternity is at stake. Joy in God is deep, and deep joy is never flippant.

R. C. Sproul came at the same point from God's holiness. "I believe that the one attribute of God that should inform our thinking about worship more than any other is His holiness." Worship, he said, should carry "a certain gravitas, a certain solemnity." Hebrews agrees: "Let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe, for our God is a consuming fire" (Heb. 12:28–29). Notice that Hebrews says this to Christians under the new covenant, people who have come not to the terrifying mountain of Sinai but to Mount Zion, to Jesus and his blood (Heb. 12:18–24). Grace has not made God less holy. It has brought us close enough to see how holy he is.

Sproul also reminds us that God made us as whole people, body and soul. "The whole person is to be engaged in the experience of worship." God designed the tabernacle with gold, color, and beauty. We stand, kneel, lift our hands, sing with our voices, eat bread, and drink wine. Worship is not merely an idea in the head. But every part of us is engaged in response to the truth, not as a substitute for it.

Room for Tears

One more thing follows. If our worship is shaped by the truth, it will not always feel happy. Baucham said it plainly: when we understand the gospel rightly, there will be moments when we feel we need to "go crawl up under something and die." And then he added, "but never be left there because there is good news."

That is the shape of real worship, and the Psalms are full of it. Isaiah saw the Lord high and lifted up, heard the seraphim crying "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts," and his first words were, "Woe is me! For I am lost" (Isa. 6:3, 5). Then the coal touched his lips and his guilt was taken away (Isa. 6:7). The psalmist could cry, "Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me?" and in the same breath answer himself, "Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God" (Ps. 42:5–6). Piper's list of the affections that belong in worship even includes contrition.

Think back to the two funerals. The second funeral was not cold. People wept. But their tears were held by the truth. That is what worship shaped by the Word can do that worship shaped by feelings never can. It can carry the grieving, the guilty, and the broken, because it does not depend on how anyone feels that morning. It depends on who God is.

Part Seven: All of Life

> **Romans 12:1** *"I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship."*

Sunday is not the only place we worship. Paul spends eleven chapters of Romans unfolding the mercies of God: our sin, God's justice, the cross, justification by faith, the Spirit, adoption, the sure hope that nothing can separate us from God's love. Then he says "therefore." In view of all that, give him everything. Your body. Your life. All of it.

λογικη` λατρεία *(logikē latreia)*

"spiritual worship" (ESV), "reasonable service" (KJV), "true and proper worship" (NIV)

λογικός (logikos)

"reasonable, rational, fitting"

Worship that makes sense in light of what God has done. The only logical response to mercy.

+

λατρεία (latreia)

"service, religious worship"

The word for the worship of the tabernacle (Heb. 9:1, 6) and for Israel serving God, the same word Jesus used in the wilderness: "him only shall you serve."

Payoff: The translations struggle because the phrase holds two ideas at once. It is "spiritual" in the sense that it is no longer animals on an altar but our own selves. And it is "reasonable" in the sense that it is what anyone who understood the mercies of God would do. Paul takes the language of the temple and spreads it over the whole week. The worship of the temple now fills your work, your marriage, your Tuesday afternoon.

The Old Testament had already been pointing this way. The Hebrew verb *ʿābad* means both to work and to worship. It is used of Adam working the garden (Gen. 2:15) and of the priests serving at the tabernacle (Num. 3:7–8). When Moses stood before Pharaoh, God's demand was, "Let my people go, that they may serve me" (Exod. 8:1). God did not free Israel from slavery so they could do whatever they liked. He freed them to worship. Rescue always leads to worship.



"Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord" (Col. 3:23). In the Old Testament, one Hebrew word means both work and worship.

MacArthur insists that worship is our first priority and that it reaches into everything: "Our all-inclusive response to God, our chief priority, is pure, acceptable worship." Paul says it about the most ordinary things imaginable: "So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God" (1 Cor. 10:31). A mother changing diapers, a mechanic under a truck, a nurse on a night shift, a man in a cubicle answering email can all be priests at the altar, offering their work to God through Christ.

That is also why Sunday matters so much. The gathered worship of the church is not a break from real life. It is where the scattered worship of the week is gathered up, corrected, and renewed. We come in tired, distracted, and full of the week's idols. We hear the Word, confess our sins, sing the truth, take the bread and the cup, and receive the blessing. And then we are sent back out to live it. Piper famously said, "Missions exists because worship doesn't. Worship is ultimate, not missions, because God is ultimate, not man." Every act of love and every word of witness during the week aims at one thing: more worshipers, from every tribe and language and people and nation, gathered around the throne.

The Turn: The Song That Never Ends

Worship is not only the way we spend Sunday. It is where history is going. In Revelation 4 and 5, John is taken up into the throne room of heaven, and what he finds there is a worship service. Living creatures cry day and night, "Holy, holy, holy" (Rev. 4:8). Elders fall down and cast their crowns before the throne (Rev. 4:10). Then the Lamb who was slain takes the scroll, and heaven breaks into a new song:

> **Revelation 5:9, 12** *"Worthy are you to take the scroll and to open its seals, for you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation. … Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"*

Everything we have studied is in that song. It is sung to God and to the Lamb. It praises Christ for who he is and for what he has done, "you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed." It is sung by priests made from every nation (Rev. 5:10). And it is full of joy and full of awe at the same time.

At the very end of the Bible, John sees the holy city come down from heaven, and he notices something missing. "And I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb" (Rev. 21:22). There is no more need for a building, a curtain, or a priestly family, because the whole city is the dwelling place of God. Every inch of it is holy ground, and every moment of it is worship. The gathering you attend this Sunday, with its off-key singing and crying babies and imperfect sermon, is a rehearsal for that day.

Jesus told the Samaritan woman, "You worship what you do not know." So let me ask you plainly: do you know the God you worship? You can sing in church for years and never bow to him. You can feel moved by the music and still be a stranger to the Savior. The Father is still seeking worshipers. He sent his Son to the cross to make them. He sends his Spirit to bring them home. If you have never come to him, come now, just as you are, through Jesus. "Whoever comes to me I will never cast out" (John 6:37). His blood is enough to make you a priest. His love is big enough to hold you. And his worship is the one thing you were made for.

And if you do know him, then come to church this week expecting to meet him. The band may be good, and you may feel something. But come because the King of kings has freed you by his blood, made you a priest, and invited you near. Bow down. Lift your voice. Give him your Monday. And remember that every song you sing here is practice for the one we will sing forever.

Seven Practices for Worshiping in Spirit and Truth

1. **Ask the right question.** On the drive home from church, trade "Did I like it?" for "Was God honored, and did I hear his Word?" The first question makes you the judge. The second makes you a worshiper.

2. **Prepare your heart before you arrive.** Read the passage that will be preached, if you know it. Confess your sins on Saturday night. The Puritan pastor Jeremiah Burroughs asked in *Gospel Worship* (1648), "I must Sanctify God's Name, and how can I do that, except my heart be Sanctified?"

3. **Pray to the Father, through the Son, by the Spirit.** Let your prayers and your attention to songs be Trinitarian (Eph. 2:18). Thank each person of the Godhead for what he has done.

4. **Start with who Jesus is.** Before you sing "he loves me," remember who "he" is: the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, the ruler of the kings of the earth (Rev. 1:5).

5. **Let the truth stir your heart.** Pay attention to the words you sing. If a line is true, mean it. If it is not true, do not sing it. Let your feelings follow what you understand, as Edwards taught.

6. **Hold style loosely and substance tightly.** Do not divide a church over organs and guitars. Do stand firm on the preaching of the Word, prayer, the sacraments, and the gospel.

7. **Make Monday an altar.** Offer your work, your marriage, and your ordinary hours to God as "a living sacrifice" (Rom. 12:1). Gathered worship on Sunday gathers up the scattered worship of the week.

The Words We Studied

Word	Where	What it shows us
προσκυνέω (proskyneō)	Matt. 4:10; John 4:20–24; Rev. 19:10	To bow down. Worship begins with submission to someone greater.
אֵשׁ זָרָה (ʾēsh zārāh)	Lev. 10:1; Exod. 30:9	Unauthorized fire. Worship that comes from us instead of from God's word.
πνεῦμα, ἀλήθεια (pneuma, alētheia)	John 4:23–24	Spirit and truth. Worship of the Father, by the Spirit, through the Son who is the Truth.
βασίλειον ἱεράτευμα (basileion hierateuma)	Exod. 19:6; 1 Pet. 2:9; Rev. 1:6	A royal priesthood. Every believer may draw near through Christ.
λογικὴ λατρεία (logikē latreia)	Rom. 12:1	Reasonable, spiritual worship. All of life offered in response to mercy.
עָבַד (ʿābad)	Gen. 2:15; Exod. 8:1	To work and to worship. God frees his people so they can serve him.

For Discussion

1. Before this study, how would you have defined worship? What did your definition leave out?
2. Think about the two funerals. What did each service assume about God? Which one is your own worship life more like?
3. Calvin said the human mind is "a perpetual forge of idols." What idols are you most tempted to bring with you into church?
4. Read Leviticus 10:1–3. Why was God so severe with Nadab and Abihu? What does "which he had not commanded them" teach us about worship?
5. What is the difference between the elements and the circumstances of worship? Why does that distinction protect both God's authority and our freedom?
6. Jesus says the Father is seeking worshipers (John 4:23). How does it change things to think of God as the one who seeks?
7. Why does it matter that we start with who Jesus is before we celebrate that he loves us?
8. Edwards said strong emotions are "no sign one way or the other." Is that freeing or unsettling to you? Why?
9. Romans 12:1 calls all of life worship. What would it look like to treat your work this week as an act of worship?

Sources & For Further Study

- **Text:** Genesis 2:15; Exodus 3:12, 14; 8:1; 19:6; 24:9–11; 30:9; Leviticus 9:24; 10:1–3; 18:21; Numbers 3:7–8; Deuteronomy 12:32; Psalm 42:5–6; 95:6; 117:1; Isaiah 6:1–7; Jeremiah 7:31; Zechariah 4:2–6; Matthew 4:9–10; John 2:19–21; 3:5–8; 4:19–29, 39; 6:37; 7:39; 14:6, 31; 17:24; Acts 2:42; Romans 1:21–25; 3:11; 6:9; 12:1; 15:1–3; 1 Corinthians 10:31; 14:23–26, 40; 16:1–2; 2 Corinthians 13:14; Ephesians 2:18; Colossians 3:16, 23; 1 Timothy 4:13; Hebrews 9:1–7; 10:19–22; 12:18–29; 1 Peter 1:18–19; 2:5, 9; 1 John 4:8; Revelation 1:1–6, 12; 4:5, 8, 10; 5:9–14; 13:4, 8; 19:10; 21:22. English quotations follow the ESV.
- **Greek and Hebrew:** BDAG on προσκυνέω, πνεῦμα, ἀλήθεια, ἱεράτευμα, λογικός, λατρεία; HALOT on זָר and עָבַד. On John 4:23–24: D. A. Carson, *The Gospel According to John* (Pillar); Andreas Köstenberger, *John* (BECNT). On Revelation 1:4–6: G. K. Beale, *The Book of Revelation* (NIGTC); Robert Mounce, *The Book of Revelation* (NICNT).
- **Creeds and confessions:** Westminster Confession of Faith 1.6, 21.1–5; Westminster Shorter Catechism Q. 1, 50–51; Heidelberg Catechism Q&A 96, 98 (CRC 2011 translation); Belgic Confession Art. 32; Nicene Creed.
- **Reformers and Puritans:** John Calvin, *The Necessity of Reforming the Church* (1543), and *Institutes* 1.11.8, 1.12.1 (Beveridge translation); Jeremiah Burroughs, *Gospel Worship* (1648), Sermons 1 and 3; John Owen, *Of Communion with God the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost* (1657), Part 1, ch. 2; Stephen Charnock, *A Discourse upon Spiritual Worship*; Jonathan Edwards, *Religious Affections* (1746).
- **Later voices:** Voddie Baucham, sermon on Revelation 1:4–6 ("The Dangerous Philosophy Behind Modern Worship"); Gene Edward Veith, "A Tale of Two Funerals," *Tabletalk*; Sam Waldron, "The Regulative Principle of the Church 2: Its Historical Meaning" (CBTS, 2012); R. C. Sproul, "How Should We Then Worship?," "Strange Fire," and "Sight, Place, and the Presence of God," ligonier.org; John MacArthur, *Worship: The Ultimate Priority*, and sermons "Worship as God Intends" (GTY175), "Acceptable Worship," and "Straight Talk About the Seeker Church Movement" (GTY90), gty.org; John Piper, "God Seeks People to Worship Him in Spirit and Truth" (1984), "The Pursuit of God in Corporate Worship" (2008), "Gravity and Gladness" (2011), and *Let the Nations Be Glad!*, desiringgod.org; Timothy Keller, "Evangelistic Worship" (Gospel in Life, 2001), "How to Talk About Sin in a Postmodern Age" (TGC, 2017), and "Counterfeit Gods: The Personal Story" (2010).
- **For further reading:** R. C. Sproul, *A Taste of Heaven: Worship in the Light of Eternity* (the best place to start); John MacArthur, *Worship: The Ultimate Priority*; D. A. Carson, ed., *Worship by the Book*; Jeremiah Burroughs, *Gospel Worship* (modern edition, Soli Deo Gloria).



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